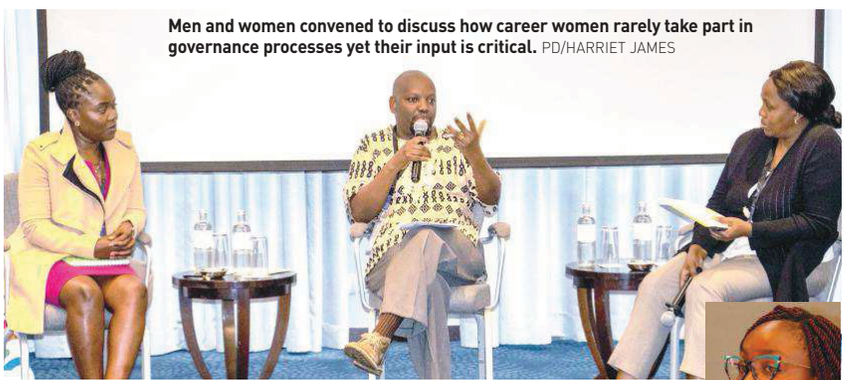
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Professional women need to participate in civic duties

Majority of the female working class rarely take part in governance, politics and even development conversations. For years, such discussions have been relegated to be poor man's issues



Men and women convened to discuss how career women rarely take part in governance processes yet their input is critical. PD/HARRIET JAMES

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In a rapidly evolving world, the significance of diverse representation in civic spaces has never been clearer. The question has always been on the role of professional women in such space and the unique perspectives and expertise that they can bring which has a potential of transforming civic spaces. The inclusion of women from diverse professional backgrounds enriches decision-making processes and enhances the effectiveness of governance. In addition, when professional women occupy civic roles, they serve as powerful role models and mentors for younger generations. Their presence can inspire and guide aspiring female leaders, helping to build a pipeline of future leaders who are equipped to make a difference in civic life.

Yet, in Kenya—a nation with a rich history of progressive change—professional women remain underrepresented in crucial decision-making roles. Despite notable strides towards gender equality, the participation of professional women in civic spaces continues to lag behind, raising questions about the barriers they face and the historical context shaping their involvement. Recently, professional women from diverse sectors met at an event dubbed, "Her Impact-professional women transforming civic spaces", to discuss the way forward and how to bring more professional women into the civic space.

"We began this new programme as we realised that there is a gap where more grassroot women are engaging more in the civic space than their professional counterparts. Professional women are keen on their careers, their families. As a country, we are growing and it's upon these professionals to drive the next wave of change and that's why they need to be involved in these conversations," explains Benard Meda, the executive director of Citizen Advancement Initiative (CAI), an organisation that supports women empowerment.

Meda notes that during the 2022 elections, politicians pushed a narrative of forming an inclusive government that featured the *mama mboga*, but the situation shifted when the professional women were appointed to the constitutional offices. This was an irony since even though they were appointed, a good percentage of them did not take part in the election process as the exercise was perceived "to be above them".

"This is why we need professional women to start being active in matters governance, oversight and accountability. In addition, the perception out there is that the civic space belongs to the NGOs and we have many other groups such as the church, professional bodies who should also be part of it. But it's the professional women who can bring accountability," he says.



EUNICE

"Women are powerful but only when speaking in one voice. If we had continued with the same momentum, we would not be speaking of the same issues. that are still recurring, like the two third gender rule

Women's involvement

Kenya's history of women's involvement in civic spaces reflects a broader narrative of struggle and progress. From the early days of independence, women have fought for their rightful place in the political and public arenas. Pioneers like Grace Ogot and Phoebe Asiyo, Martha Karua, Charity Ngilu broke ground in politics, but the journey towards equitable representation has been fraught with challenges. The introduction of legislative reforms and the push for gender quotas have marked significant milestones, yet systemic barriers have continued to inhibit full participation.

"During that time, women had one voice and they all had gender as their agenda. What they meant by that is that they desired political representation in all spaces and they organised themselves in movements like the Maendeleo Ya Wanawake of which I was the coordinator in Siaya county. They were so organised and they knew who to lobby, the allies to bring on board which included men so as to achieve their goals. They also did civic education at the grassroot level so that they could speak in one voice," explains Eunice Oyule - County Coordinator for the National Steering Committee. She adds "Women are powerful but only when speaking in one voice. If we had continued with the same momentum, we would not be speaking of the same issues that are still recurring, like the two third gender rule. How come, a half of the population in this country are still considered as a marginalised group, yet they are half of the population? Is it because we have so many issues to tackle that we don't know where to start from?" she adds.

Eunice says even though there have been major strides made by women in the professional space, they still experience inequalities in access to education, FGM, early marriages and also gender based violence. These issues are cross cutting in all women. One of the things that the leader is advocating for is to deconstruct the patriarchal systems through active engagements. "We should engage in civic discourses because, the civic space is shrinking and what that means is that we have to look for ways of voicing out our issues," explains Eunice.

The barriers

Despite progress, professional women face significant barriers to taking part in the civic dialogues. These obstacles include systemic issues such as gender bias, lack of supportive networks, and inadequate mentorship opportunities. They also face structural challenges, such as the imbalances of power and entrenched cultural norms, further complicating the path for women seeking to participate fully in civic life. "The demanding nature of civic roles often clashes with professional and personal responsibilities, creating an additional hurdle for women who juggle multiple roles. The lack of flexible work arrangements and support systems exacerbates these challenges, making it difficult for many professional women to commit to civic duties," notes Irene Otto, an Advocate and an official of the Law Society of Kenya (LSK). Otto says women also fear being castigated by the public since leadership positions expose individuals to the public, which then attracts scrutiny and ridicule from citizens, leading to the unceremoniously forfeiture of these positions.

The women's forum then identified the media as an important player in shaping public's perception and creating narratives, setting and building agenda around professional women's inclusion. "Most women who got into politics learnt how to present themselves through media. The challenge that we are having is that most women shy away from sharing their achievements," shares Topista Nabusota of Kenya Union of Journalists (KUJ). Toepista adds that women need to not only know how to present themselves in the mainstream media but also the digital space. She says they also need to identify the key issues that they are good in professionally and be ready to talk about them in the media. "We need to redefine the issues that are impeding women's progress. We are so lost that we don't know the issues that we are fighting for. There is also lack of institutional memory in some of the organisations fighting for change in women and the current generation have failed to continue with the history of advocacy. That's why we need learned women in these conversations," she continues.



LOVE & LAST WITH WAITHERA OTIENO

Lessons from divorced men and women

After the divorce and the dust has settled, post-divorce reflection begins. As the divorcees adjust to not being married, they realise that they could have done things differently, and ended up happier in their marriage. Here are some lessons those who have divorced wish you should do:

Always choose to be kind to each other. Kindness is about generosity. It is also about using kind words, having kind thoughts and showing your spouse regular acts of kindness. When your spouse makes a genuine mistake, do you blame them or do you support and encourage them to fix the problem? When they are weak and vulnerable, do you reach out to help and use kind words or do you neglect and/or castigate them? Do you do small meaningful things for them because you know they like those things- such as fixing their favourite drink when they are upset? A kind word in the middle of an argument can stop you from going into serious disagreement.

Your marriage cannot fix your mental health condition. If you were unhappy before the marriage, you will still be unhappy during the marriage. Find your joy and your happiness by yourself first, so that you can share some of it with your partner. Don't expect your partner to be the source of all your joy.

Have things that you like to do together and things you like to do separately. This gives the relationship space to breath. Don't forget your hobbies, dreams or friends because your partner doesn't like them. Also, if there are things your spouse likes to do, but you aren't keen on them, give them the space to enjoy those things. Then together, find things that you both enjoy.

Always ask 'how will this affect the relationship?' When you get married, you and your spouse create a separate entity, made up of you, and them. All major decisions should be passed through the litmus test of 'how does this help the relationship?' If both of you prioritise the relationship, then the relationship will thrive. If you prioritise yourselves selfishly, the relationship becomes weak. Your mantra should be 'It is us against the world, not us against each other'

Talk about what you need from your partner. Say what you need from the relationship. Bottling up feelings and hiding your desires will make you unhappy in the long run. Don't use silent treatment to communicate your unhappiness. Your partner cannot read your mind. Speak up with love.